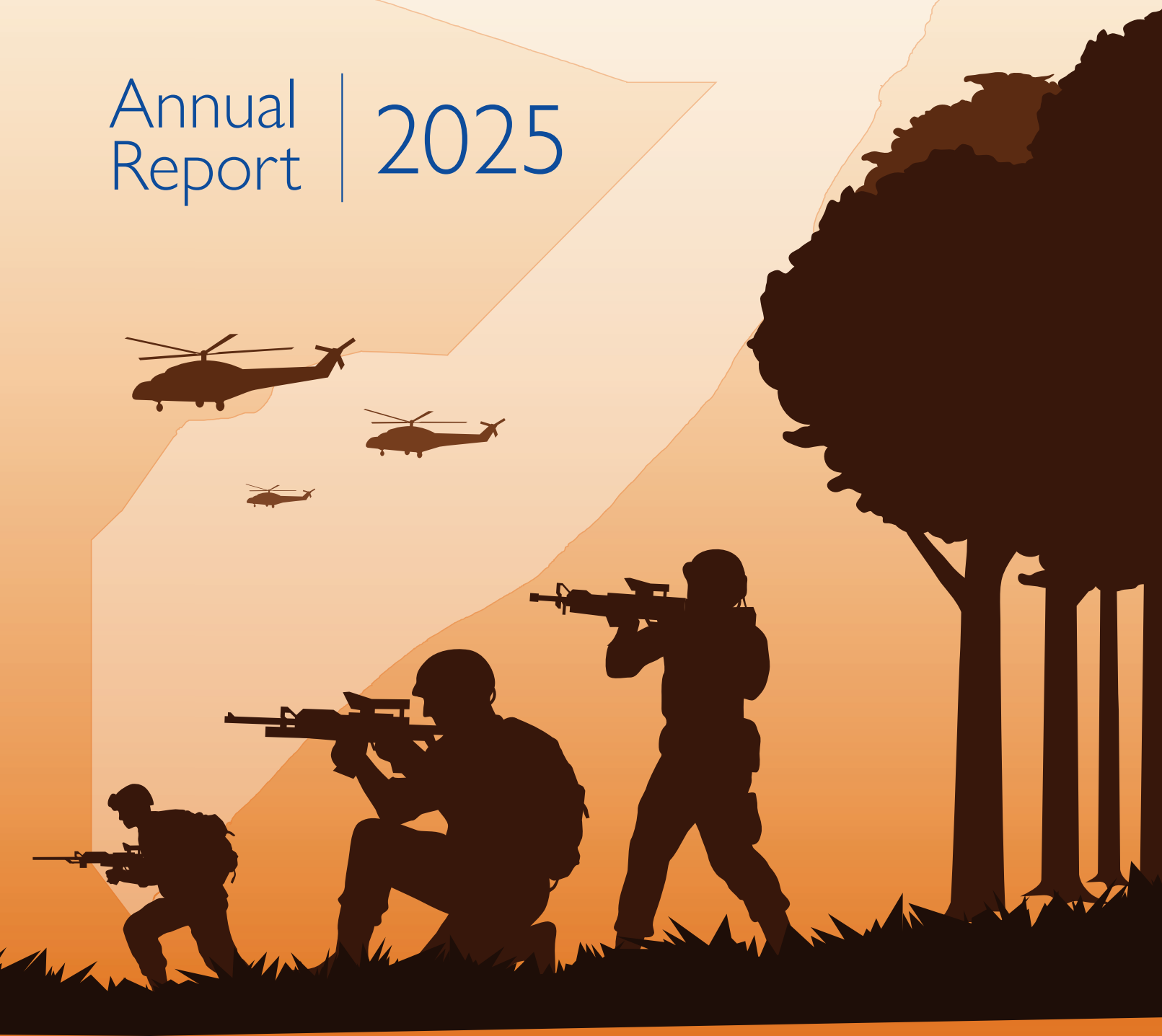
IOM
UN MIGRATION

CONFLICT TRENDS IN SOMALIA

Annual Report | 2025



Annual Report: Conflict Trends in Somalia in 2025

Copyright © International Organization for Migration - Somalia @2026

All rights reserved.

Acknowledgements

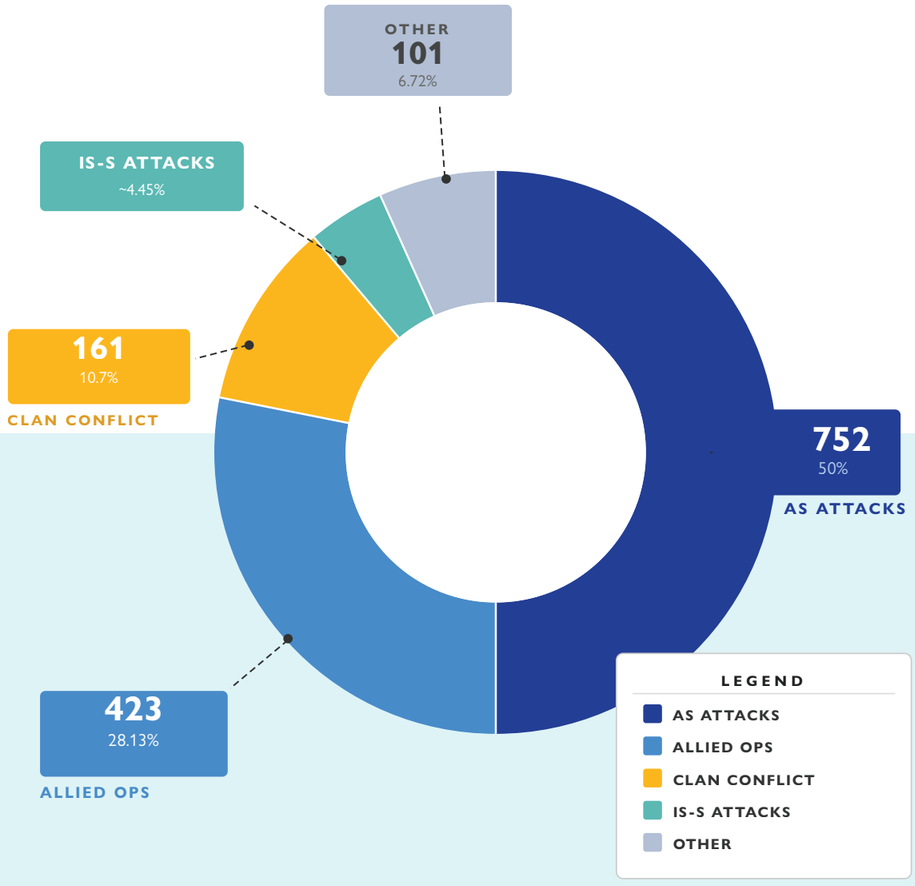
Contributors: IOM Somalia Community Stabilization Unit

Editor: Jan Havlicek

Design and Layout: Jagnoor Hunjan

Summary

In 2025, IOM recorded 1,502 violent incidents in Somalia. As in previous years, the main driver of conflict and insecurity was al-Shabaab (AS). The group was responsible for approximately half of all violent incidents (752), recorded primarily in Southwest State (432), Mogadishu (112), Hirshabelle State (107), Jubaland State (93), and Galmudug State (8). Notably, there were no attacks by AS in Puntland, where the group continued efforts to recover from losses suffered during 2023 at the hands of the Islamic State group's "Somalia Province" (IS-S). In contrast, all attacks attributed to IS-S (67) took place in the Bossaso and Qandala districts of Bari Region, with few signs of low-level activity from the group's network in Mogadishu. In response, there were 423 "allied operations" targeting AS (327) and IS-S (87). Instability and insecurity also continued to be fuelled by clan-based violence. During 2025, the majority of the 161 incidents recorded took place in Galmudug State (49), followed by Hirshabelle (30), Somaliland (27), Southwest (23), Puntland (14), Jubaland (12), and Northeast (6) states. There were also at least 19 incidents of conflict between the SNA and other pro-government forces and clan-based militias or other actors.



1502 violent incidents analysed in 2025 (4.2 incidents per day on average)

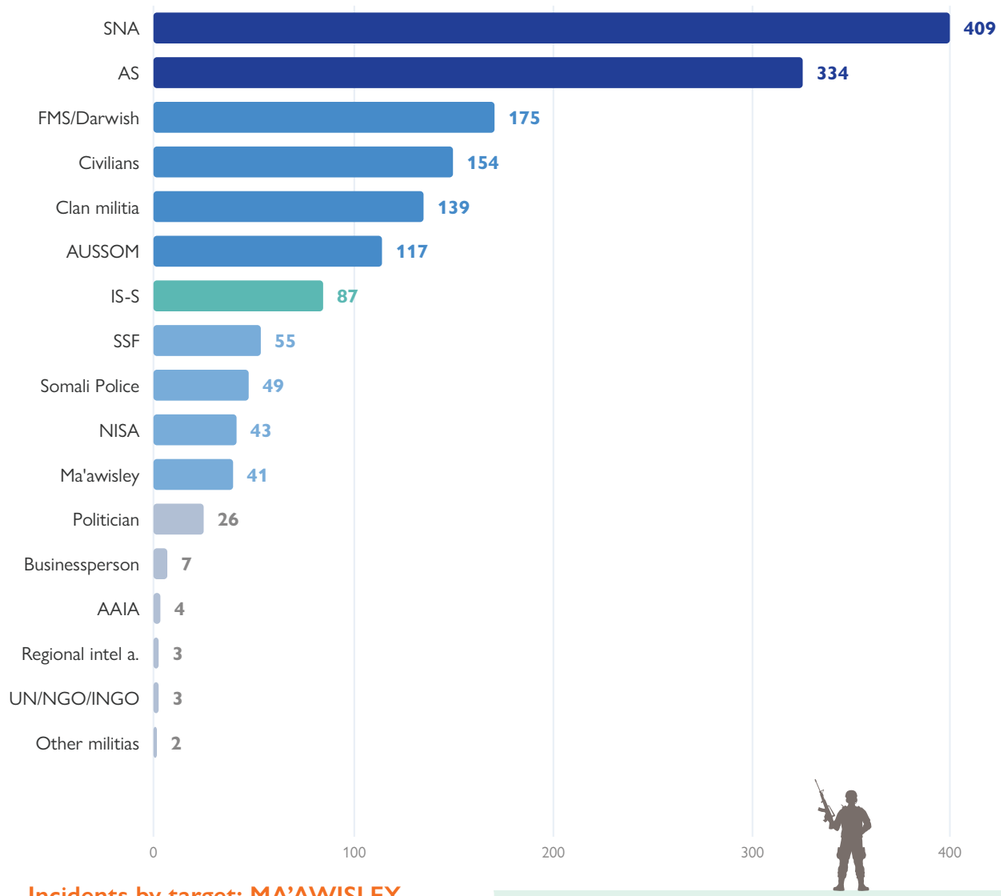
Key numbers:

AS ATTACKS	ALLIED OPS	IS-S ATTACKS	CLAN CONFLICT
752	423	67	161
TOTAL INCIDENTS	TOTAL INCIDENTS	TOTAL INCIDENTS	TOTAL INCIDENTS
DAILY AVG 2.06	DAILY AVG 1.16	WEEKLY AVG 1.3	WEEKLY AVG 3.0
incidents / day	incidents / day	incidents / week	incidents / week

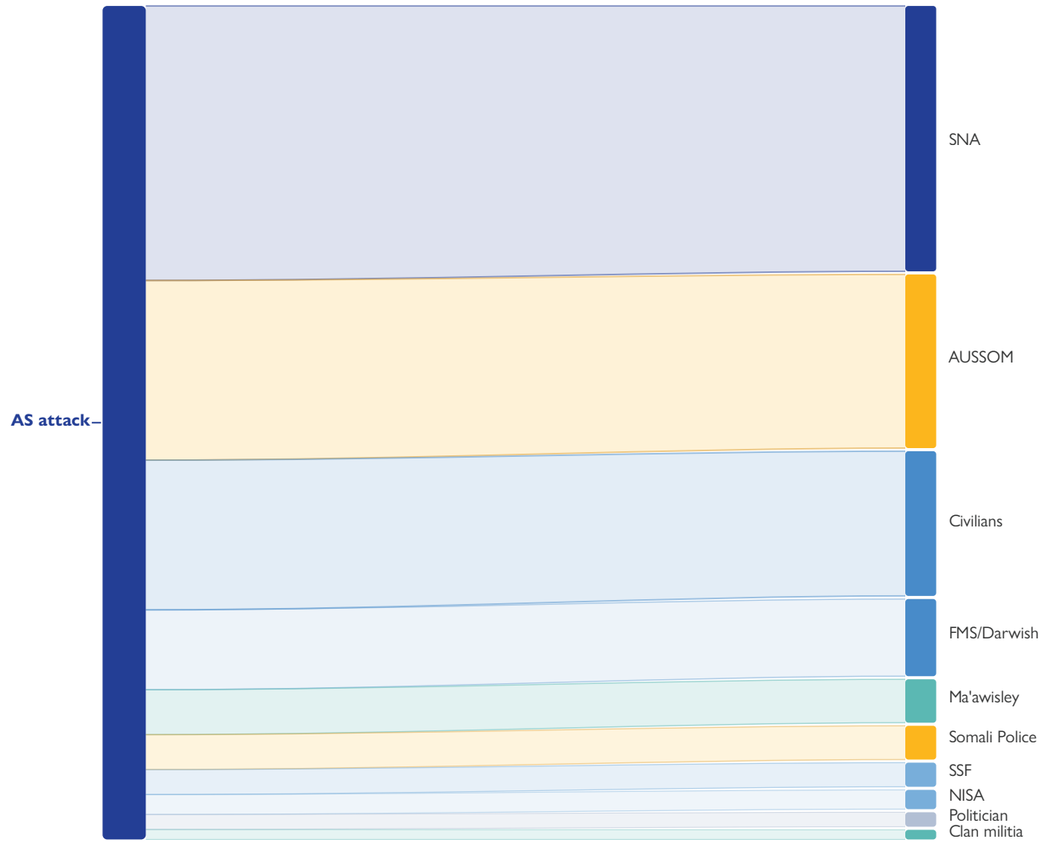
Incidents by target: AAIA

There were four (4) shelling incidents targeting the Aden Adde International Airport (AAIA) during which AS fighters employed mortars or 107mm rockets from stocks captured from ATMIS/AUSSOM forces. Fired from positions on the capital's outskirts, these weapons proved highly inaccurate, with 28 April rockets aimed at the airport landing across multiple districts. The concentration of all shelling incidents within April-June and the limited total number may indicate dwindling supplies of captured 107mm rockets and mortar rounds. The reliance on captured ordnance rather than indigenous production, achieved by other insurgent groups, including jihadist rival IS-S, suggests AS's technical limitations in weapons manufacturing despite the group's sophisticated explosive device capabilities.

Incidents by targets



Targets of AS's attacks



Incidents by target: MA'AWISLEY

During 2025, Ma'awisley clan-based militias were attacked by AS at least forty-one (41) times in Hirshabelle and Galmudug states, though attack patterns diverged from those observed in other regions. Despite the relatively low number of attacks, marked by no Ramadan spike and a decline after a June peak, AS achieved significant territorial gains in April and during the June–July–August period. This reduction in incidents in which Ma'awisley were targeted may also partly reflect AS's use of amnesty offers for Ma'awisley fighters and coercive deal-making with local communities.

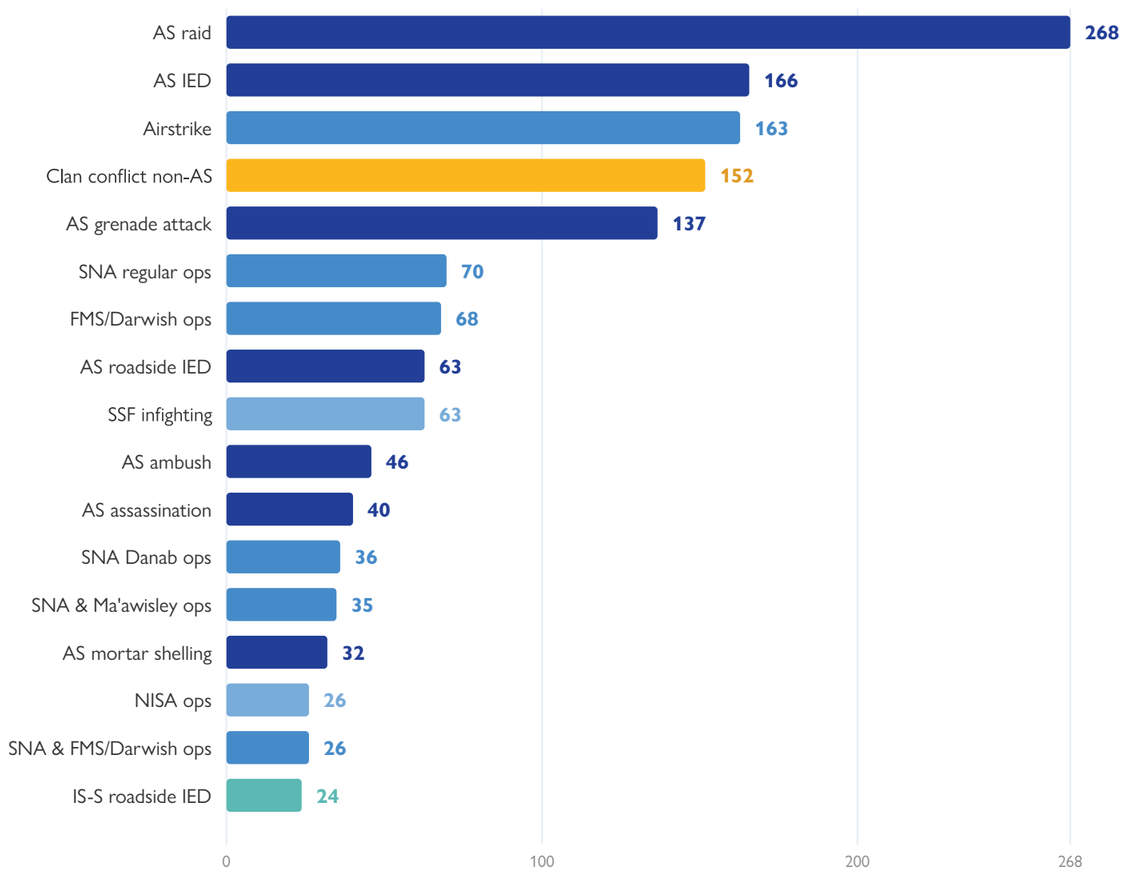
High number of airstrikes

In 2025, U.S. AFRICOM and other international partners conducted at least 109 airstrikes targeting AS and 53 strikes against IS-S. Air operations against AS were largely reactive and unevenly coordinated with ground offensives.

Jubaland State accounted for nearly half of all airstrikes targeting AS (45%), a share that intensified during the final quarter of the year, when the SNA and Jubaland Security Forces (JSF) advanced in Jamame District. In Hirshabelle, 37 airstrikes were reported (34%), including at least 20 during Ramadan in Jowhar, Adan Yabal, and Adale districts. However, this tempo was not sustained – only seven strikes were carried out between June and August, even as AS captured multiple strategic settlements, including Hawadley, Moqokori, Mahas, Tardo, Gobo, Wabweyn, and Qowl. Southwest State experienced only 18 airstrikes (18% of the total), despite accounting for at least 432 AS attacks nationwide (57%), with no airstrikes in Baidoa District despite high attack rates and multiple allied ground operations.

In Puntland, U.S. AFRICOM and the UAE targeted IS-S with at least 53 airstrikes, proving a key factor behind the Puntland Defence Forces' (PDF) gains. These strikes intensified during the final quarter, October (7), November (9), and December (7), as ground forces consolidated control over areas liberated since late 2024.

Incidents by type



Infighting among pro-government forces

Most instances of infighting involving the SNA and other pro-government forces were relatively minor, lasting only minutes and resulting in few casualties. Such incidents typically occurred at checkpoints due to disputes over vehicle searches or illegal taxation. However, there were also several more serious incidents:

» **Beled Hawo:** At least ten clashes between pro-FGS forces (typically SNA and NISA) and the JSF took place in Beled Hawo (Gedo Region) and its immediate environs during 2025. These clashes were linked to a conflict over the control of regional and district-level authorities in Gedo. Notably, the conflict between federal and Jubaland state authorities has created divisions in Marehan communities in Beled Hawo, including the split within the Reer Ahmed sub-clan. While some members of the community loyal to Abdirashid Janan, the former Jubaland Security Minister and District Commissioner of Dolow, have sided with the FGS, others, led by figures such as General Yusuf Hussein Osman "Dhumal", the Jubaland Minister for Security, have sided with Kismayo.

» **Ras Kamboni:** In late 2025, SNA troops were routed by the JSF at Ras Kamboni (Badhadhe District, Lower Juba Region), with more than 600 seeking refuge across the border in Kenya.

» **Bardhere:** Another clash between the SNA and JSF was reported in Bardhere, which, together with Garbaharey, is expected to remain a potential flash point even in 2026.

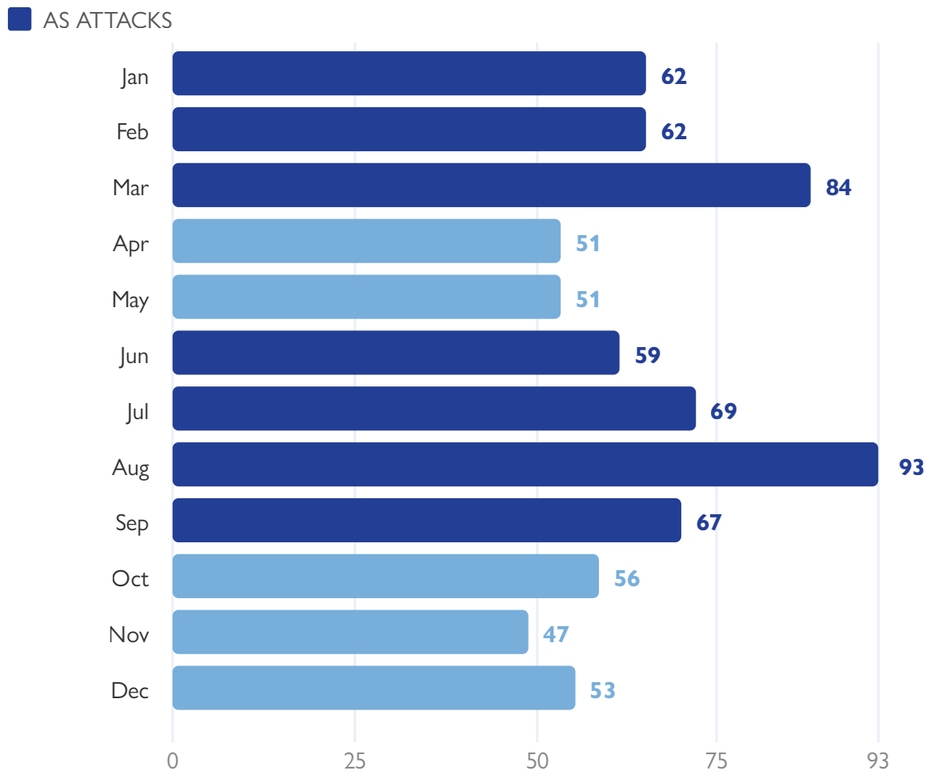
» **Marka:** On 28 November, two groups of SNA soldiers exchanged gunfire in Marka (Lower Shabelle Region) following a dispute between the District Commissioner and his deputy over activities by the National Identification and Registration Authority (NIRA). The incident highlights the risks that voter registration activities continue to face outside Mogadishu in towns where political tensions are elevated, and security forces are divided along clan lines (e.g., Beledweyne, Qoryoley, Beled Hawo, Garbaharey).

Emerging risks

» **Puntland:** Tensions persist between forces loyal to the Puntland State administration—Darwish and the Puntland Maritime Police Force (PMPF)—and forces aligned with the federal government, including the so-called "Danab" units led by Gen. Jim'ale Jama Takar and the Puntland Security Force (PSF) militia led by Gen. Mahmoud Diyano and his family. Conflict could erupt if Puntland authorities attempt to disarm these federal-aligned forces. Additionally, potential violent clashes between Puntland forces and Northeast State forces (and allied Dhulbahante militias) could trigger a broader confrontation between Puntland and the FGS.

» **Somaliland:** In early December, tensions between Gadabursi and Isse communities in Awdal Region erupted into sporadic inter-communal violence. The instability was initially triggered by controversy over plans to hold events commemorating UNESCO's recognition of Xeer Ciise – the traditional oral law of the Isse clan. With many pre-existing intercommunal disputes over land ownership and access to natural resources, there is a risk that deaths and injuries from retaliatory attacks may lead to a rapid deterioration of the security environment in Awdal Region.

AS attacks — monthly count 2025



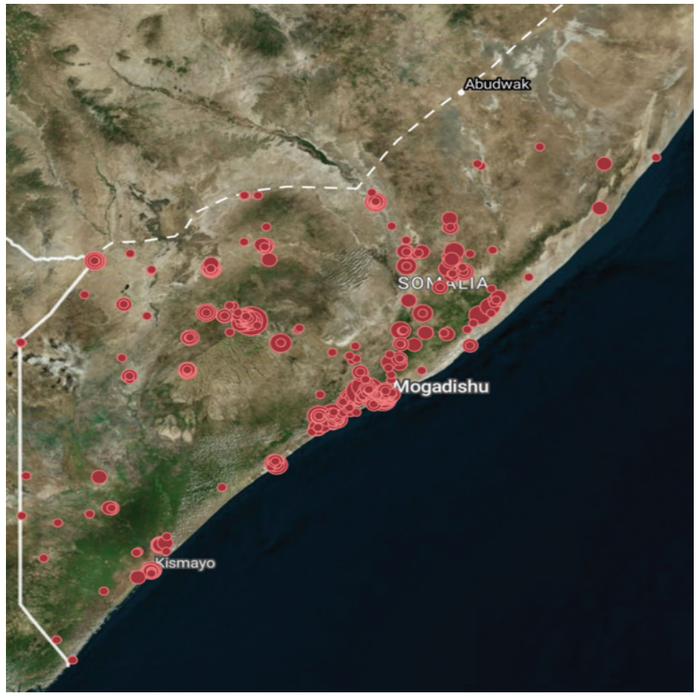
Attacks attributed to al-Shabaab

In 2025, AS attacks followed a typical cyclical pattern seen in previous years. The first quarter saw a spike during Ramadan (1-30 March), reflecting the group's annual offensive linked to Salafi-Jihadist ideology, which places increased value on military actions during this period due to its association with jihad and martyrdom in Islam.

As in previous years, April and May saw a decline in attacks, coinciding with the annual Gu rainy season (April-June), when river levels rise, and roads become difficult or impossible to travel on. However, because rains fell inconsistently across south-central Somalia, attacks—while reduced—remained steady and even increased in June as roads became more passable and the Shabelle River levels dropped, facilitating greater movement.

The **spike in attacks in August** was driven by increases in incidents in the Southwest State, especially the Lower Shabelle and Bay regions. There was also a surge of attacks in Mogadishu, using IEDs and grenades, which we were unable to explain. Notably, there were declines in the number of attacks in both Jubaland and Hirshabelle; however, AS continued to make small territorial gains in the Hiran Region.

Attacks declined gradually during the **final quarter.** While previous years saw reductions during the Deyr rainy season (from September/October to December), the 2025 failure of these rains resulted in severe, rapidly worsening drought conditions across south-central Somalia. Even though this is speculative, this could have affected AS's logistics. Another speculative reason for this decline could be the group's use of the year-end period as a time of rest, resupply, and reorganisation before intensifying attacks in the weeks leading up to the annual Ramadan Offensive, which in 2026 runs approximately from mid-February to mid-March.



Locations of AS attacks in 2025

As seen in the map above, attacks by AS in 2025 were concentrated in the Southwest state, with the majority of incidents recorded in the Afgoye (138) and Baidoa (114) districts, followed by Marka (69). In Afgoye District, areas of particular focus were the strategically important "bridge towns" of Awdhegle, Barire, and Sabid-Anole, which were overrun and held by al-Shabaab for some time. During April–July, AS also concentrated military resources in the Middle Shabelle Region. While the overall number of attacks was low, these resulted in the capture of the strategically important towns of Adan Yabal, Moqokori, Aborey, Yasoman, and Mahas, all of which remained under the group's control till the end of the year.

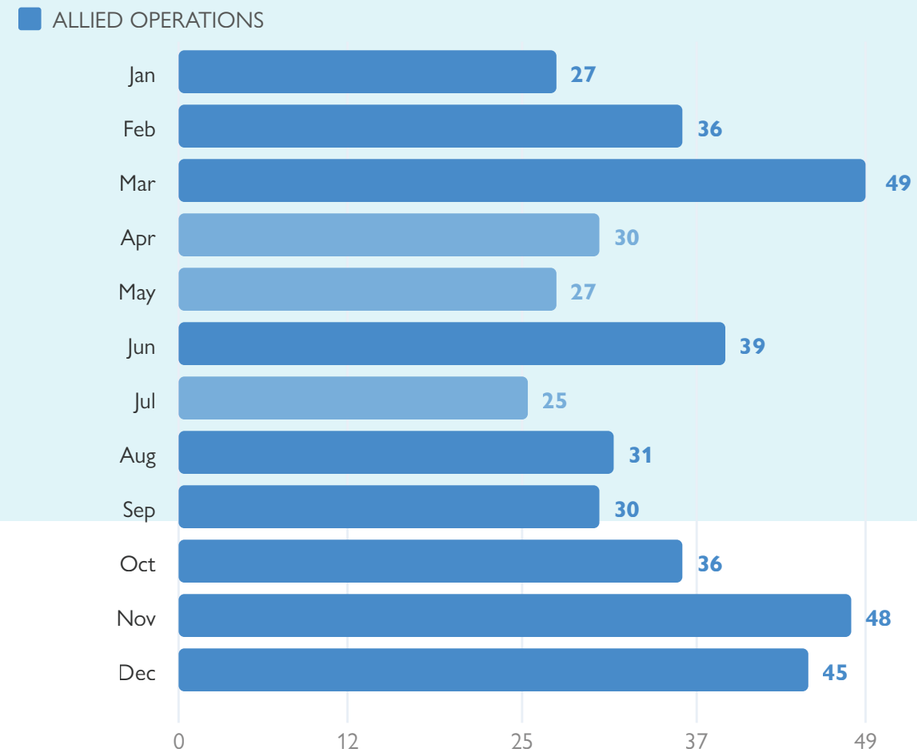
Notably, no attacks were recorded north of Qayib in Dhusamareb District (Galgadud Region) or the city of Hobyo in Hobyo District (Mudug Region). This failure to expand northwards is due to several factors, including the strength of Puntland security forces and the group's inability to exploit inter-clan conflicts. Although AS fighters operate across parts of the Golis/al-Maddow Mountains, stretching from west of Bosaso (Bari Region) to Erigavo (Sanag Region), there were no attacks on Puntland, where the group continues to recover from defeats at the hands of IS-S in 2023–2024. In Somaliland, unconfirmed reports indicate that the group maintains an informal truce with the authorities of the self-declared independent region, resulting in no attacks during 2025.

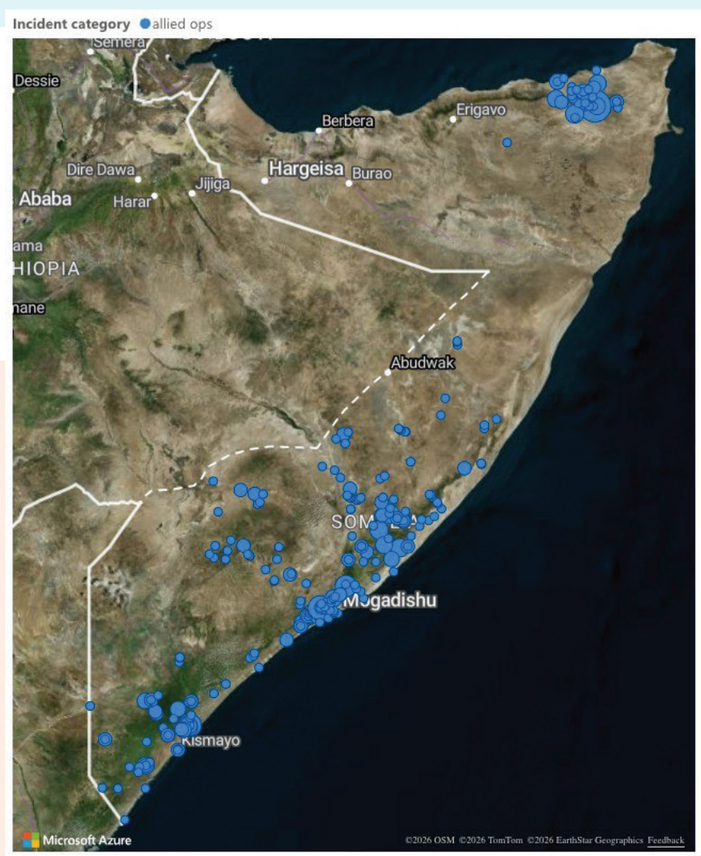
Allied operations in 2025

In 2025, there was limited correlation between operations targeting AS by the SNA, AUSSOM, other Somali security actors (e.g., state paramilitary forces and Ma'awisley militia), and international partners (e.g., U.S. AFRICOM) and attacks by the militant group.

While operations increased from January to March, AS attacks also increased, but there was no corresponding spike in militant activity in August. Likewise, the increase in allied operations during the fourth quarter of 2025 was driven largely by an offensive against AS outside Jamame (Jamame District, Lower Juba Region) and IS-S in the al-Miskad Mountains of Bari Region, even as attacks by both groups declined.

Based on these trends, while IS-S remained operationally constrained under sustained military pressure, AS appears to have retained the strategic initiative against the SNA and its local and international partners. An example of the latter was observed during SNA's efforts to retake the key "bridge towns" of Sabid-Anole, Barire, and Awdhegle, which were a series of uncoordinated local counter-offensives that still struggled to overcome fierce resistance despite support from AUSSOM units and airstrikes.





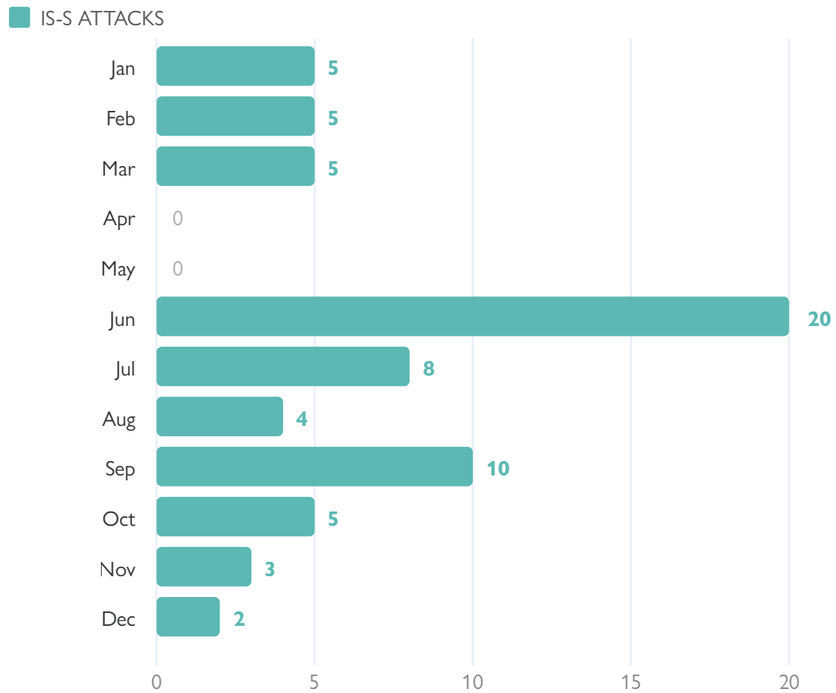
Attacks attributed to the Islamic State – "Somalia Province" (IS-S)

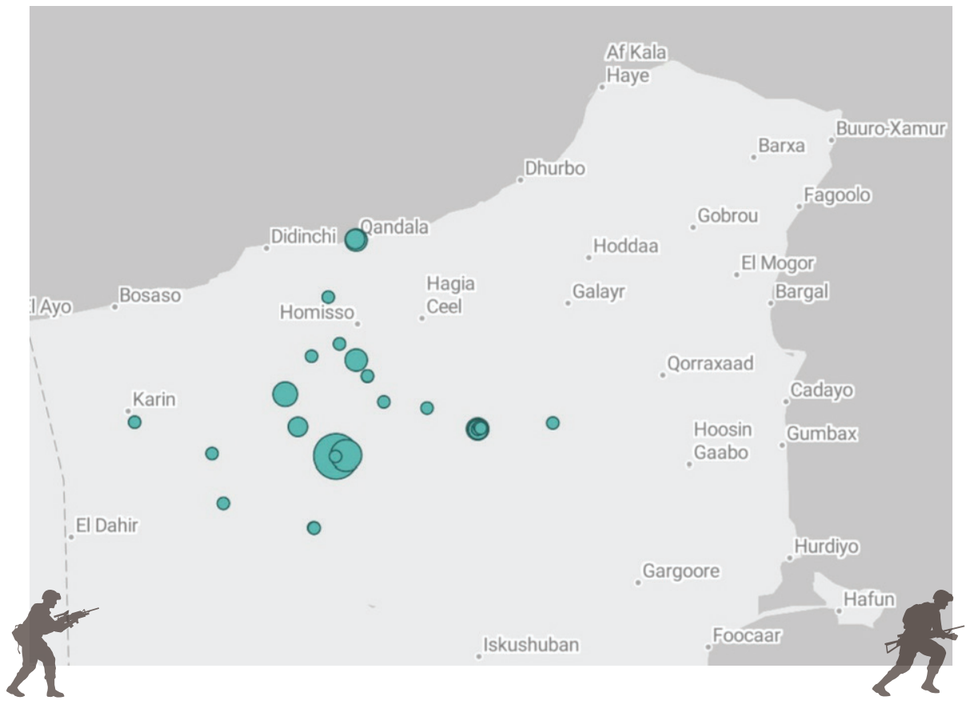
Overall, there were at least 67 attacks attributed to IS-S in 2025, all of which occurred in the Bosaso (19) and Qandala (48) districts of the Bari Region. While there was a significant spike in the number of attacks in June (20), the militant group remained on the operational defensive.

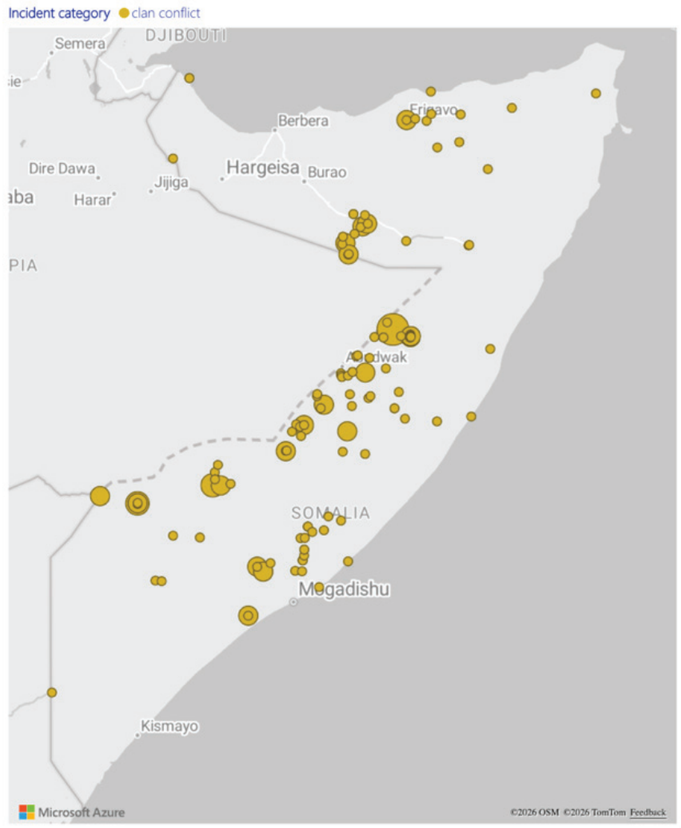
There were only two notable attacks by the group during the year. The first occurred on 9 February, when IS-S fighters used seven (7) drones to target PDF personnel. The second was a complex assault on a PDF base on 16 November, involving at least nine (9) militants wearing person-borne improvised explosive devices (PBIEDs).

In total, at least fifty-three (53) airstrikes by U.S. AFRICOM and other international partners targeted IS-S in 2025. These strikes have continued even as Puntland officials claimed to have secured 95-98% of the al-Miskad Mountains, and to have destroyed over 80% of the leadership and military capabilities of IS-S.

IS-S attack — monthly count 2025







Clan-based conflict

In 2025, clan-based violence in Somalia was correlated with seasonal patterns amid widespread drought conditions following the largely failed Gu and Deyr rains across south-central regions. Conflicts spiked dramatically between October and December, suggesting that worsening resource scarcity fuelled inter-communal tensions. However, localised factors, including livestock rustling, blood feuds, failure to pay compensation under reconciliation agreements, and political power struggles, also contributed to intercommunal violence.

Marehan vs Dir in Abudwaq District, Galgadud Region: On 10 December, clan militias clashed in the Bangelle area, resulting in 25 deaths and 33 injuries. The incident was triggered by disputes over access to grazing land and unresolved blood debts. The unusually high number of casualties complicates efforts to achieve conflict resolution and reconciliation between communities due to the substantial amount of diya (blood compensation) that would need to be paid.

Gadabursi vs Isse in Awdal Region: Plans to hold an event commemorating UNESCO's recognition of Xeer Ciise caused long-running tensions between the communities to escalate into violence. On 4-5 December, protests by members of the Gadabursi community in Borama turned violent when soldiers and police used live ammunition to disperse demonstrators. At least 19 people were killed, and more than 200 were

wounded. With already simmering inter-communal tensions over separatism, land ownership, and access to natural resources, events in Borama triggered new rounds of inter-communal violence, including clashes between clan-based militias.

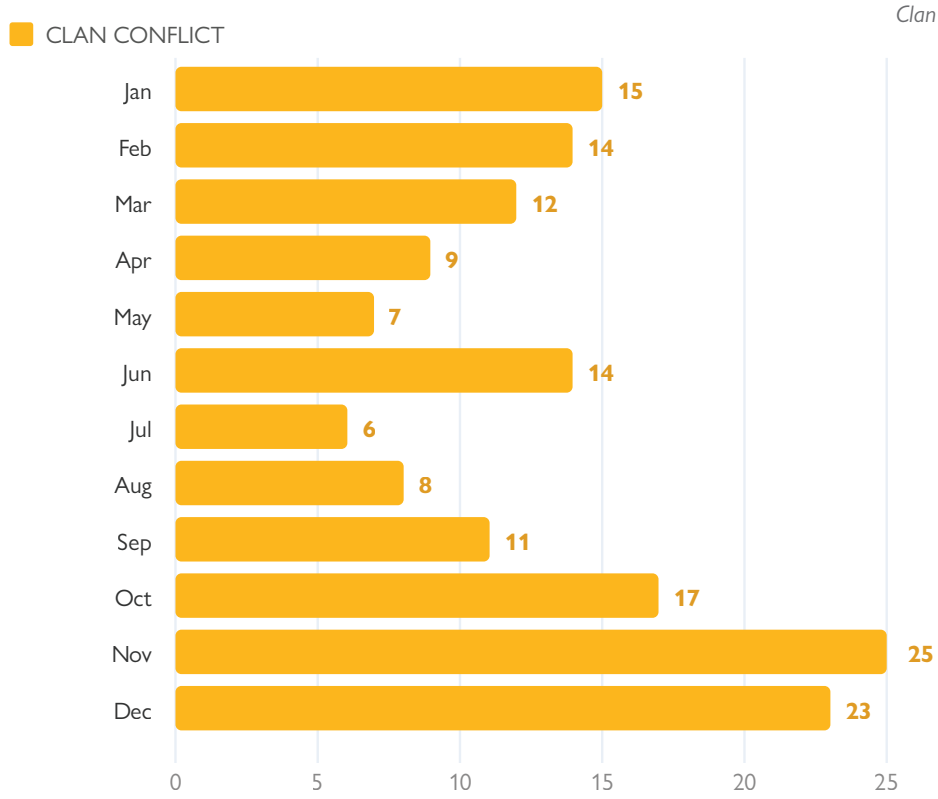
Galje'el vs Shanta–Alemod in Wanlaweyn District, Lower Shabelle Region: Escalating clan violence erupted in late 2025 following the brutal murder of an elderly man outside Wanlaweyn, sparking cycles of revenge killings. The violence displaced at least 1,500 families from Galje'el communities in Dudumay, Gareri, Beled Amani, and Awgadud. Nine (9) individuals were sentenced to death by a military court for their involvement, while others were sentenced to terms of imprisonment. Operations by the SNA and SWSPF to restore security have encountered armed resistance from the Galje'el militia.

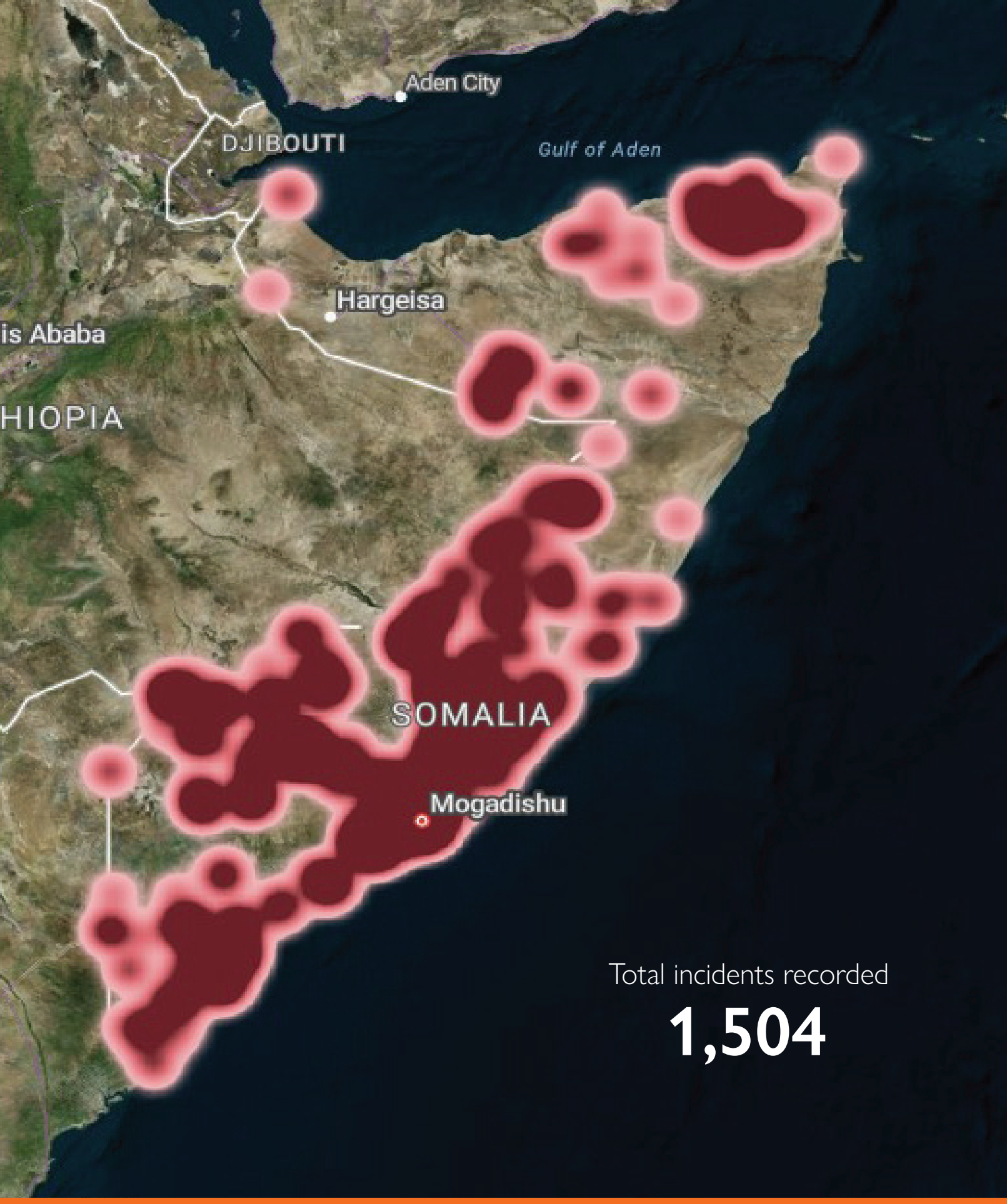
Galje'el vs Shanta–Alemod in Wanlaweyn District, Lower Shabelle Region: Escalating clan violence erupted in late 2025 following the brutal murder of an elderly man outside Wanlaweyn, sparking cycles of revenge killings. The violence displaced at least 1,500 families from Galje'el communities in Dudumay, Gareri, Beled Amani, and Awgadud. Nine (9) individuals were sentenced to death by a military court for their involvement, while others were sentenced to terms of imprisonment. Operations by the SNA and SWSPF to restore security have encountered armed resistance from the Galje'el militia.

Dhulbahante vs Isaq in Sool and Sanag regions: Incidents of camel rustling and retaliatory attacks continued to fuel instability and risk reigniting the frozen conflict between Somaliland and the Northeast State (previously SSC-Khatumo).

Marehan and Gabawayn vs Moalim Weyne in Luuq District, Gedo Region: Long-standing tensions over land ownership, dispute over the control of Gedo Region between federal and Jubaland authorities, and access to resources – including control of IDP camps – have fueled cycles of intercommunal violence that have displaced tens of thousands of persons. A ceasefire was brokered by the Jubaland State government in December 2025, although the long-term sustainability of this agreement remains uncertain.

Clan conflict — monthly count 2025





Total incidents recorded

1,504

IOM
UN MIGRATION